

Forward Deployed Engineer - Live Customer Simulation

Overview

Duration: 90 minutes (with flexibility for up to 30 minutes additional if needed)

Format: Virtual meeting with screen sharing

Participants: You + 2 Brightbeam team members (playing customer roles)

This session simulates a real customer engagement where you'll lead technical discovery, problem exploration and solution ideation. You'll work with stakeholders to understand their problem, explore potential AI-enabled solutions, and collaboratively build something that demonstrates your approach.

Document Reference: This aligns with our hiring process, assessing:

- Customer interaction and stakeholder management
 - Real-time GenAI problem-solving and discovery skills
 - Technical communication with mixed audiences
 - Professional presence and collaborative approach
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The Scenario

Date Context: For this simulation, we'll assume today is Monday, November 18th, 2024.

A bit about the company:

We're a **professional services firm** of about 120 people working across multiple client projects. Each team uses slightly different tools – some use Jira, others Asana, and a lot of work ends up tracked in email or Slack. Our Operations Director struggles to keep visibility on who's overloaded, what's urgent, and what's falling behind. The Technical Lead works with the teams to compile data regularly for the Operations Director to review, but this is a manual and time-consuming process. We're exploring whether **AI could help us prioritise, summarise, or flag risks earlier** without introducing another complex tool.

You're meeting with two stakeholders from the firm:

Operations Director (Non-technical)

- Frustrated with team productivity and task management chaos
- Spends hours trying to understand team status across projects
- Has heard AI might help but needs to see practical value
- Concerned about adoption and whether people will actually use any solution

Technical Lead (Technical)

- Responsible for team's tooling and processes
- Compiles the data export for Operations Director regularly
- Technically curious about AI but sceptical about "magic solutions"
- Concerned about implementation feasibility and maintenance burden

They've shared a data file representing their current task management situation – a CSV export the Technical Lead has compiled from their various systems. The data is messy and reflects real-world complexity - incomplete information, inconsistent formats, and unclear priorities.

Your Role: Lead a technical discovery session to understand their challenges and collaboratively explore potential AI-enabled solutions through live development.

Pre-Session Preparation (Before the Meeting)

Review the Sample Data

Download and familiarise yourself with `tasks_data.csv` (see separate file)

The data represents:

- Tasks assigned to various team members
- Actions required with varying urgency
- Follow-ups from meetings and client interactions
- Projects at different stages
- Mix of structured and unstructured information
- A snapshot compiled from multiple systems (Jira, Asana, emails, Slack)

Important: It's not necessary to build a complete solution in advance. Review the data enough to ask good questions, but the session is about collaborative discovery and live solution development.

Prepare Your Environment

Ensure you're ready to:

- Develop and demonstrate ideas for solutions during the session

- Display visualisations or interfaces that stakeholders can react to
- Iterate quickly based on feedback
- Share your screen effectively

How you work is up to you: Use whatever tools and approach you're most comfortable with - whether that's coding in VS Code, Cursor, Windsurf, Vim, or Emacs; using AI coding assistants like GitHub Copilot, Claude Code, or Aider; or working with tools like Lovable, Bolt, ChatGPT, Claude, or Gemini to generate and demonstrate solutions. The goal is to show software concepts, elicit requirements, and provoke a stimulating problem-solving and discovery conversation.

Session Structure

The session will flow through three natural phases:

Discovery & Problem Understanding

Your objectives:

- Understand the stakeholders' actual challenges (not just what they say they want)
- Explore the data together to identify patterns or issues
- Ask questions that reveal priorities and constraints
- Begin forming hypotheses about what might be valuable

Expect:

- Stakeholders may have different priorities
- Initial requests might not be the real problem
- You'll need to balance technical and business perspectives
- Discovery should drive what you build, not the other way around

Collaborative Solution Exploration

Your objectives:

- Build something live that helps explore solutions
- Use visualisations or prototypes to drive conversation
- Demonstrate how AI could help with real examples
- Iterate based on stakeholder feedback
- Make technical trade-offs transparent

This could involve:

- Visualising the current situation to spark insights
- Building a simple proof-of-concept for a specific capability
- Demonstrating how LLMs could process or enhance the data
- Creating interactive explorations of potential solutions
- Showing multiple approaches and gathering feedback

What we're looking for:

- How you balance building vs. discussing
- Your ability to explain technical concepts clearly
- How you incorporate stakeholder feedback in real-time
- Whether you ask questions before making assumptions
- Your approach to demonstrating AI capabilities

Wrap-up & Next Steps

Your objectives:

- Summarise what you've learned and demonstrated
 - Outline potential approaches worth pursuing
 - Discuss implementation considerations
 - Gather final feedback and questions
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What Success Looks Like

Excellent Discovery Skills

- Asks sophisticated questions about current workflows and pain points
- Identifies underlying issues beyond initial stated requirements
- Understands both technical and business constraints
- Balances exploration with progress toward tangible outcomes

Strong Stakeholder Management

- Keeps both technical and non-technical stakeholders engaged
- Explains complex GenAI concepts clearly to different audiences
- Handles conflicting priorities or feedback constructively
- Maintains credibility throughout the session

Effective Real-Time Problem Solving

- Adapts approach based on new information

- Makes pragmatic decisions about what to build vs. discuss
- Demonstrates AI capabilities through concrete examples
- Shows good judgment about technical feasibility

Professional Presence

- Maintains collaborative, helpful demeanour
- Handles ambiguity and uncertainty well
- Asks for clarification when needed
- Shows genuine curiosity about the problem

Cultural Mantra Demonstration

We'll be observing how you embody Brightbeam's cultural mantras:

- **Always be helpful** - Everything starts with "Given the current situation, how can we be most helpful?"
 - **Deliberately fair** - Balancing everyone's needs to create outstanding outcomes for all
 - **Learn and grow together** - Learning and building what's needed to solve tomorrow's challenges collaboratively
 - **Show, don't tell** - Creating confidence through demonstrable results
 - **Bias for action** - Being a doer who shows what's possible, not just talks about it
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Important Notes

This Is Not About...

-  Building a complete, production-ready system
-  Having all the answers prepared in advance
-  Impressing us with complex algorithms
-  Polished UI or perfect code

This IS About...

-  How you lead technical discovery
-  How you collaborate with stakeholders
-  How you explore solutions through demonstration
-  How you communicate technical concepts
-  How you approach real-time problem-solving

Technical Expectations

- Work in whatever way is most comfortable for you
- Don't worry about perfect solutions - working exploration is better than polished features
- Focus on demonstrating understanding and capability, not completeness
- It's fine to talk through ideas you'd explore with more time

If Things Don't Work

- Network issues, bugs, or unexpected problems happen
 - How you handle them is part of what we're observing
 - Ask for help or clarification if you need it
 - Talking through your thinking is valuable even if software isn't running
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Preparation Checklist

Before the session, ensure you have:

- ☐ Downloaded and reviewed `tasks_data.csv`
 - ☐ Set up your development environment and tested it works
 - ☐ Tested your screen sharing setup
 - ☐ Confirmed video/audio working
 - ☐ Prepared some initial questions about the problem space
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Questions?

If you have any questions before the session:

- Technical setup issues: Contact us immediately
 - Clarifications about the scenario: Ask during the session (that's part of discovery!)
 - Data questions: Review it, but save detailed questions for the session
 - LLM API costs: Let us know and we'll provide credits if needed
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What Happens Next

After the session, we'll evaluate:

- How you led technical discovery and stakeholder engagement
- Your real-time problem-solving and solution exploration approach

- Your communication and collaboration effectiveness
- Your technical capabilities and approach to problem-solving
- How well you demonstrated our cultural mantras in action

This session, combined with your take-home technical challenge, gives us comprehensive insight into how you work with customers and solve real problems.

We're excited to see how you approach this challenge!